# Empanada for a Dream

## or Dios te va Castigar (God Will Punish You)

## By Juan Francisco Villa

**JUAN:** You have not tasted heaven until you have had one of my mom's homemade ***empanadas de carne molida***. (ground beef empanadas) The one thing I craved every day of my life. The one thing I would trade all my Batman comic books for -- no -- my Batman **and** X-Men comic books for was a homemade empanada.

CRRRRRRRACK of dawn all the women are up. ***Mi Abuelita*** (grandmother) Consuelo, my mom, my ***Tias*** (aunts) Negra and Martha, my sisters Sandra and Jenine, my cousins Giselle, Sohanny, Xiomarra, and Carinoso and whoever else happened to be staying at our place would get up for the birthday/holiday ritual.

They would break off into teams. One team would get the harina (cooking flour) to mold with the water and then pancake it flat with a homemade ***plancha*** (flat iron). Another would make the homemade pique (traditional hot sauce from Puerto Rico). What my friends still talk about to this day. The immortal pique that as long as you had a metal spoon in it, would never go bad. . . according to my mom. Another team made ***el desayuno*** (breakfast) for everyone in the apartment. Scrambled eggs with tomatoes and green onions soaked in ***Manteca*** (butter). Do not call it a Denver omelette. Do not call it Huevos a la Mexican (Mexican eggs). ***Son huevos perico!*** (They are parrot eggs!) That smell would wake up all of apartment 3A.

By afternoon the empanadas were made. By evening the entire neighborhood was knocking on our door. By night the empanadas were gone. My mom's Colombian empanadas were legendary in the Caribbean dominated neighborhood. You have not tasted heaven until you have had one of my mom's homemade ***empanadas de carne molida.***

Birthdays were fun growing up. They always are when you are a kid. Everyone pitched in to make it as fun as possible. The morning of, the victim would wake up and as they were being

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hugged and kissed with birthday wishes, a barrage of raw eggs were smashed on their head. It's a Colombian tradition. For good luck. Colombia and it's traditions. *(beat, then solemnly)* I hated being Colombian.

## INTRODUCTION

*When Juan Francisco Villa's mother immigrates to NYC from Colombia at the young age of 19, she couldn't imagine what life had in store for her. She quickly finds a community of extended family and other Colombian immigrants on the Lower East Side, but the harsh realities of living in a foreign land plunge her family into the dark underworld of cocaine trafficking.*

*Villa captures his own child-like wonder of the American dream and the dangerous choices some make when the dream is not so easy to achieve.*

*Empanada for a Dream or Dios te va castigar (God will punish you) by Juan Francisco Villa*

**JUAN:** To be Colombian was to NOT be American. The last time I was in Colombia, I could see them milk their cows and it tasted nasty. It tasted like the earth. And I'm no organic foods connoisseur. I don't care about no "the closer it is to the tree the better it is for you." No, "the closer it is to a tree" the more it tasted like an immigrant.

Colombians only know how to play futbol (American soccer). They didn't have Levi jeans, and they always stared at my Spanish. My American English cartoons were all in Spanish over there. I couldn't understand anything.

The worst part was coming back home. Security would endlessly question us at the airport. We would always be detained and put in a room where they would rip apart our suitcases cuz they "had an inside tip on us." They would never find anything.

My mom at 19 was the first to immigrate here in the states. She was the pioneer of the family. She was lonely. She met my father: boisterous, charming, possessive and addicting.

It is 1981. My mom, my pops, my sis, Little Juan Francisco Villa, all of us snuggled together, sleeping together in one bed. Freezing [our] little Colombian asses off but warm with the laughter of love and opportunity of life here in the 6th floor of 169 Allen St. Such an American thing to have, apartment buildings that go past the 3rd floor. Until my mom left

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my pops and moved us to the 3rd Floor of 169 Allen St. the Lower East Side, New York.

My uncles were like fathers to me after my mom kicked my pops out. *(beat)* I have this memory. It was my birthday. I was turning 11 years old, and my uncles would want to splurge on me, but my mom was not a fan of it.

**MAMI:** ***No lo trate asi.*** (Don't treat him like that) I don't want him to feel like a king. ***Como un*** (Like an) Americana thinking he doesn't have to work for anything. No! When you do not work hard. ***Dios te va castigar.*** (God will punish you.)

**JUAN:** Somehow pushing me to accept that I will never get what I dream of having. Hard work gets you closer but it's never enough. So my uncle, Tio Alvaro. He would be like

**TIO ALVARO:** Juanita! It's your birthday. Whaddaya want? I can give it to you. ***Toda lo que quiera. Cuando yo era pequeno no tenia nada.*** (Whatever you want. When I was little, I had nothing.)

**JUAN:** Wooooooow! No one ever said that to me. No one ever asked me what I really wanted. So I said: MCDONALDS!!!!! Yeah. That's what I said. $.39 hamburgers and $.49 cheeseburgers. Now, this was back in the day when I could eat, and eat, and eat. I was a scrawny kid, but I could throw down with the best of them. My Uncle says . . .

**TIO ALVARO:** How many you want? Don't be ashamed. How many you want? ***Es tu cumpleanos*** (It's your birthday) . . . DREAM BIG.

**JUAN:** I would look at my mom. She would sigh and I would belt out **4 CHEESEBURGERS!!!!** *(to audience)* I get them and chomp them down fast.

**TIO ALVARO:** Diablo Juanita. You ate them fast. Like a big strong man. You want more?

**JUAN:** SI! 4! 4 Mas! *(to audience)* So I now have had a total of 8 and I am feeling good.

**TIO ALVARO:** Wow, Juanita. ***Todavia tienes hambre?*** (Are you still hungry?)

**MAMI:** No mas. He's already eaten a lot. And he's going to get sick.

**TIO ALVARO:** Leave him alone. He's a little boy. Juanito, you still hungry.

**JUAN:** 4 mas! . . . por favor. *(to audience)* And there was a gasp all around us. I didn't even know people were paying attention to me.

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**MAMI:** Be careful God is going to punish you.

**JUAN:** So I sat down and ate 4 more cheeseburgers bringing my total up to 12! I barely was able to get the last one in. I felt like a king. And we walked home and no one talked. I was sauntering with a smile. My uncle was bobbing with a smile and my mom was grimacing all the way home, not happy that I got what I wanted.

I get home and within 40 minutes my stomach is killing me. I feel like I am possessed by a demon. Seriously, I was doing the whole Gremlins in sunlight writhing in pain act. So I do what any 11 year old would do and . . . M*AAAAAMMMMMMIIIIIII!!!! My stomach hurts!*

**MAMI:** What did I tell you?! That you were going to get sick and God was going to punish you.

**JUAN:** *(softly)* ***Dios te va castigar.*** From that day on everything changed. And I mean for all of us. . . *(beat)* My uncles introduced coke to the neighborhood. Then it took a life of its own. My blood has caused so much pain and death in this neighborhood. My uncles murdered a lot of people.

**RITCHIE:** Your Tio Alvaro ruled this area; him and your Tio Luis. They were crazy, man. This dude was sellin some of Alvaro's stash on the side. So, he walked behind the guy. Held his head up high and just cut this dude's throat. I've never seen so much blood. Then Alvaro just walks away.

**JUAN:** ***Dios te va castigar.*** My Tio Chepe met a woman named Liliana from Colombia. She was the woman that everyone in my family loved. She was quiet. She didn't argue. She spoke Spanish. New Year's Eve party 1990 – that was the last time my entire family was together. My Tio Chepe came. Liliana was there, of course, but they left early -- she was feeling ill. They went back home deep in Queens. It was 3 am-she was like: *"I'm hungry. I want ice cream.*" He goes to get ice cream. He's gone for hours. She calls the cops. They go searching for him. He's- he's- he's lying in the street. My family gets hysterical when they get the news. We get to the hospital. There's a ventilator and I don't recognize him. He is soooo swollen. so swollen. He had gotten beat with aluminum baseball bats. You ever heard an aluminum bat hit a human head? Sounds just like hitting a baseball. Kink. kink. kink.

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4 days later. My family pulled the plug. He died. And months later we find out that this perfect woman. This perfect Colombian was in love with another man, another drug dealer. So they worked on a plan to have my uncle killed. ***Dios te va castigar.***

This entire building feels like it is in a famine. It feels post-apocalyptic. This entire building has been infested with this mindset, this transition from bettering each other to bettering themselves. The American Dream.

**MAMI:** ***ERES LAZY! Yo nose porque no sirves para nada.*** (I don't know why you're good for nothing.) I take you to church. I've sent you to the best schools. I've bought you clothes.

**JUAN:** Ma! ***Callate!*** (Be quiet!) You are constantly at me! It's never enough for you. If I get an A, then it's "Why didn't you get an A+" Oh, I'm sorry, do you not understand what I am saying? You have been in this country for 20 years. Lean English! Here's a word in English: COCAINE. That's what's in my blood. Death. Why would anyone want to say they are Columbian? My grandmother, your mother, let her own kids sell that s*** on the streets and kill sooo many of our own people from our own neighborhood who trusted us! You never stopped them either. I think God did notice. He took away your brothers. Don't you see what's happening?! ***Dios te va castigar!*** *(long beat, he is gasping for breath in his rage)*

She reaches for me and this is where it happens. *(another long beat, then softly)* This is where my mom says that I hit her. I remember all of this up to this moment. I don't remember hitting her. *(sadly)* [But I do remember] You have not tasted heaven until you have had one of my mom's homemade ***empanadas . . .***

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